Raptors of India

A beginner field guide to eagles, kites, hawks/Shikra, falcons, harriers and vultures

> **First rule:** do not identify a raptor by size alone. Distance can make a large eagle look tiny. Start with **wing shape + tail shape + flight style + habitat**, then use plumage.

What is a raptor?

Birds of prey / शिकारी पक्षी

Raptors have strong feet and hooked bills. Many catch live prey; vultures mostly eat carrion. Most eagles, kites, hawks and vultures are in Accipitridae; falcons are in Falconidae.

Useful Hindi words

चील (cheel) is commonly used for kites; **उकाब (ukaab)** for eagle; **बाज़ (baaz)** may be used broadly for hawks/falcons; **गिद्ध (giddh)** for vulture. Local usage varies.

Look at the wings

Broad and “fingered” usually points toward eagles/vultures. Long pointed wings suggest falcons. Shorter rounded wings plus long tail suit woodland hawks such as Shikra.

Look at the tail

A forked or notched tail strongly suggests a kite. A long narrow tail helps Shikra turn through trees. Eagles usually show a broader, fan-shaped tail.

Watch the flight

Kites are buoyant and constantly adjust the tail. Eagles soar more heavily and steadily. Falcons use quick, powerful wingbeats and fast direct flight. Vultures may soar for long periods with almost no flapping.

Watch the hunting style

Shikra makes fast surprise dashes from cover. Harriers quarter low over grass/reeds. Falcons chase in open air. Snake-eagles scan from exposed perches and soar over open country.

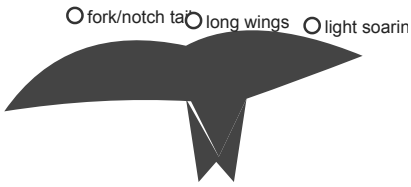
Fast comparison

Group	Typical shape	Flight	Food / strategy	Quick clue
Kite / चील	Long wings; often notched/forked tail	Light, buoyant circles; tail twists constantly	Scavenging, snatching scraps, small prey	“Floating” flight + active tail
Eagle / उकाब	Broad wings, strong body, broad tail	Heavy, steady soaring; deep wingbeats	Medium prey, reptiles, birds, mammals, carrion depending species	Powerful build; broad wings
Hawk / Shikra	Short rounded wings; long tail	Quick flap-flap-glide; agile through trees	Small birds, lizards, rodents, insects	Long tail + woodland dash
Falcon / बाज	Long pointed wings; compact body	Fast, direct; often rapid wingbeats	Birds/insects caught in air or fast pursuit	Pointed wings, speed
Harrier	Long wings and tail	Low, buoyant, side-to-side over fields	Small birds, rodents, reptiles	Low “quartering” flight
Vulture / गिद्ध	Very broad wings; small head; fingered primaries	Effortless thermal soaring	Carrion; ecological clean-up	Huge wings, tiny head, long soaring

Tip: if you only see a distant silhouette, record “raptor sp.” rather than forcing a species-level ID.

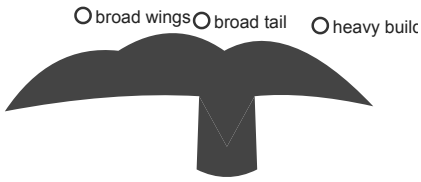
Silhouette practice: what to notice first

Kite



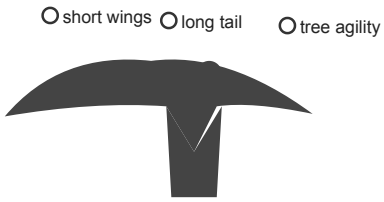
fork/notch tail • long wings • light soaring

Eagle



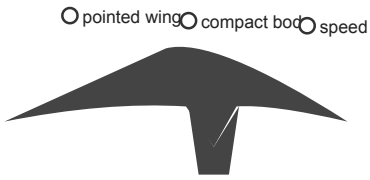
broad wings • broad tail • heavy build

Shikra / hawk



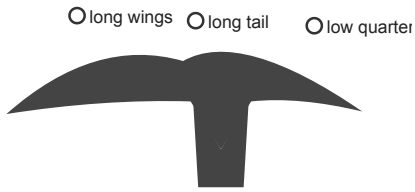
short wings • long tail • tree agility

Falcon



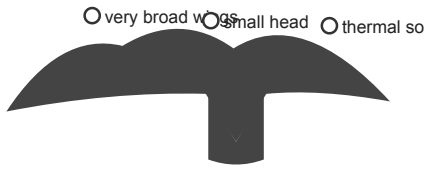
pointed wings • compact body • speed

Harrier



long wings • long tail • low quartering

Vulture



very broad wings • small head • thermal soaring

> **Beginner shortcut:** A bird circling over a city with a shallow forked tail is often a Black Kite. A compact raptor bursting through trees with a long banded tail may be a Shikra. A huge bird soaring on very broad wings with a small-looking head may be a vulture.

Common traps

“Big = eagle”

Not reliable. Female Shikra is larger than the male; perspective can exaggerate size; some eagles are surprisingly small.

“Every dark city raptor = eagle”

In many Indian cities, the dark circling raptor is much more likely to be a **Black Kite**.

“Vulture = eagle with bald head”

Vultures are specialized scavengers with extremely broad wings and soaring behavior adapted to searching huge areas.

“Falcon = hawk”

Both are raptors, but falcons typically have pointed wings and a very different flight style from short-winged, long-tailed accipiter-type hawks.

Species guide 1-4

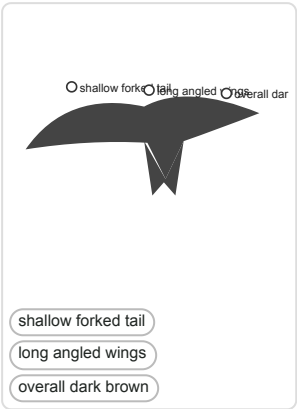
Black Kite

Kite

Milvus migrans



Jakub Hałun • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



shallow forked tail

long angled wings

overall dark brown

Where: Cities, rubbish areas, rivers, open country
Food: Carrion, scraps, fish, insects and small animals
Flight / behaviour: Buoyant circling; frequent tail steering; shallow fork/notch often visible

Quick ID: City raptor circling on a lightly forked tail.

Brahminy Kite

Kite

Haliastur indus



Challiyil Eswaramangalath Vipin from Chalakudy, India • CC BY-SA 2.0 • Wikimedia Commons



white head + breast

rich chestnut body

rounded tail

Where: Coasts, lakes, rivers and wetlands; sometimes cities
Food: Fish, crabs, carrion and small prey
Flight / behaviour: Steady soaring; rounded tail; often over water

Quick ID: Adult looks white-headed and chestnut from surprisingly far away.

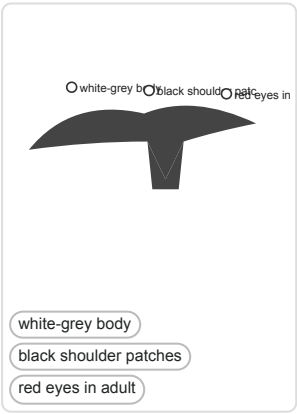
Black-winged Kite

Kite

Elanus caeruleus



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white-grey body

black shoulder patches

red eyes in adult

Where: Open fields, farmland, grassland, road edges
Food: Rodents, lizards, large insects, small birds
Flight / behaviour: Can hover; often pauses in air before dropping on prey

Quick ID: Small pale raptor that can hover like a kestrel.

Shikra

Hawk / accipiter

Tachyspiza badia



Niraj Kasar • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



short rounded wings

long barred tail

adult fine orange barring

Where: Gardens, campuses, woodland, city trees
Food: Small birds, lizards, rodents, insects
Flight / behaviour: Rapid flap-flap-glide; sudden dashes through trees

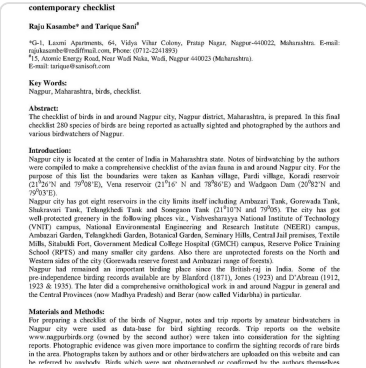
Quick ID: Long-tailed tree hunter; often appears suddenly and disappears just as fast.

Species guide 5-8

Crested Goshawk

Hawk / goshawk

Accipiter trivirgatus



contemporary checklist

Raju Kasambe* and Tarique Sani#

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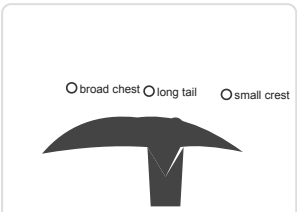
Key Words:
Nagpur, Maharashtra, birds, checklist.

Abstract:
The checklist of birds in and around Nagpur city, Nagpur district, Maharashtra, is prepared. In this final checklist 280 species of birds are being reported as actually sighted and photographed by the authors and various birdwatchers of Nagpur.

Introduction:
Nagpur city is located at the center of India in Maharashtra state. Notes of birdwatching by the authors were compiled to make a comprehensive checklist of the avian fauna in and around Nagpur city. For the purpose of this list the boundaries were taken as Kanhan village, Pardi village, Koradi reservoir (21°26'N and 79°08'E), Vena reservoir (21°16' N and 78°86'E) and Wadgaon Dam (20°82'N and 79°03'E).
Nagpur city has got eight reservoirs in the city limits itself including Ambazari Tank, Gorewada Tank, Shakravarti Tank, Telnagkhedi Tank and Sonegaon Tank (21°10'N and 79°05). The city has got well protected greenery in the following places viz., Vidhveshanayya National Institute of Technology (VNIT) campus, National Environmental Engineering and Research Institute (NEERI) campus, Ambazari Garden, Telnagkhedi Garden, Botanical Garden, Seminary Hills, Central Jail premises, Textile Mills, Sitabuldi Fort, Government Medical College Hospital (GMCH) campus, Reserve Police Training School (RPTS) and many smaller city gardens. Also there are unprotected forests on the North and Western sides of the city (Gorewada reserve forest and Ambazari range of forests).
Nagpur had remained an important birding place since the British-raj in India. Some of the pre-independence birding records available are by Blanford (1871), Jones (1923) and D'Abreau (1912, 1923 & 1935). The later did a comprehensive ornithological work in and around Nagpur in general and the Central Provinces (now Madhya Pradesh) and Berar (now called Vidarbha) in particular.

Materials and Methods:
For preparing a checklist of the birds of Nagpur, notes and trip reports by amateur birdwatchers in Nagpur city were used as data-base for bird sighting records. Trip reports on the website www.nagpuribirds.org (owned by the second author) were taken into consideration for the sighting reports. Photographic evidence was given more importance to confirm the sighting records of rare birds in the area. Photographs taken by authors and or other birdwatchers are uploaded on this website and can be referred by anybody. Birds which were not photographed or confirmed by the authors themselves

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broad chest · long tail · small crest may show

Where: Wooded hills, forests, plantations
Food: Birds, squirrels, reptiles and other small vertebrates
Flight / behaviour: Powerful short-winged flight through wooded habitats

Quick ID: Heavier forest hawk than Shikra; broad body and strong legs.

Peregrine Falcon

Falcon

Falco peregrinus



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pointed wings · dark hood/moustache · compact powerful body

Where: Cliffs, coasts, wetlands and increasingly tall city buildings
Food: Mostly birds captured in high-speed aerial pursuit
Flight / behaviour: Fast, direct, pointed-winged; spectacular stoops

Quick ID: Think speed + sharply pointed wings.

Eurasian Kestrel

Falcon

Falco tinnunculus



Dibyendu Ash • CC BY-SA 3.0 • Wikimedia Commons



pointed wings · long tail · frequent hovering

Where: Open country, fields, cliffs, urban edges; winter visitor in many areas
Food: Rodents, lizards and large insects
Flight / behaviour: Often hovers into the wind while hunting

Quick ID: A small falcon hanging almost stationary over open ground.

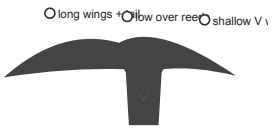
Western Marsh Harrier

Harrier

Circus aeruginosus



Shino jacob koottanad • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



long wings + tail · low over reeds · shallow V wing posture

Where: Marshes, reedbeds, wetlands and fields, especially in winter
Food: Small birds, mammals, reptiles and carrion
Flight / behaviour: Low quartering flight with wings often held in a shallow V

Quick ID: Large brown raptor cruising low over marsh vegetation.

Species guide 9-12

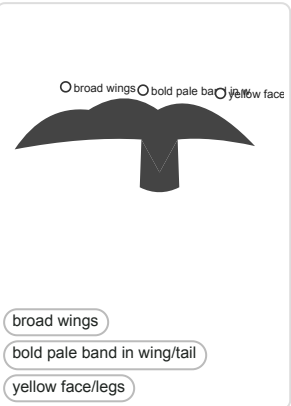
Crested Serpent Eagle

Eagle

Spilornis cheela



T. R. Shankar Raman • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



broad wings
bold pale band in wing/tail
yellow face/legs

Where: Forests, wooded hills and forest edges
Food: Snakes, lizards, frogs and small mammals
Flight / behaviour: Broad-winged soaring; often calls while circling

Quick ID: Forest eagle; broad wings and a strong pale band often stand out.

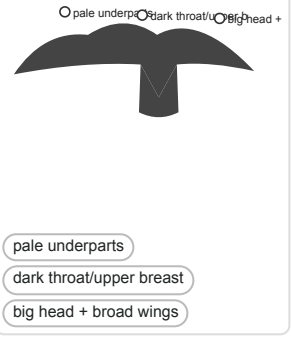
Short-toed Snake Eagle

Eagle

Circaetus gallicus



J.M.Garg • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



pale underparts
dark throat/upper breast
big head + broad wings

Where: Open scrub, grassland, dry country and farmland
Food: Mostly snakes and other reptiles
Flight / behaviour: Soars and may hover or hang in wind while scanning ground

Quick ID: Pale snake-eagle of open country, often scanning from high above.

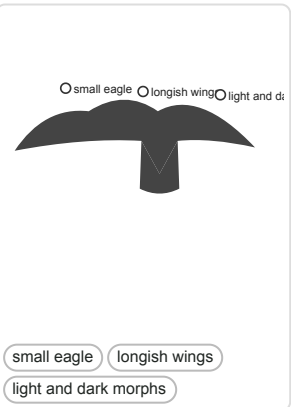
Booted Eagle

Eagle

Hieraaetus pennatus



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small eagle
longish wings
light and dark morphs

Where: Woodland, open country, wetlands and cities in winter
Food: Birds, reptiles and small mammals
Flight / behaviour: Agile eagle; often circles high and may hunt birds on the wing

Quick ID: Compact eagle; beware both pale and dark plumage forms.

Bonelli's Eagle

Eagle

Aquila fasciata



J.M.Garg • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



long broad wings
strong projecting head
adult pale body with darker wings

Where: Rocky hills, cliffs, scrub and open woodland
Food: Birds and medium-sized mammals
Flight / behaviour: Powerful, direct; also broad-winged soaring

Quick ID: A muscular, long-winged eagle of rocky open country.

Species guide 13-16

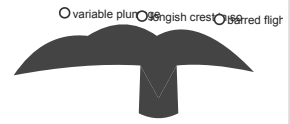
Changeable Hawk-Eagle

Hawk-eagle

Nisaetus cirrhatus



Shino jacob koottanad • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



variable plumage
longish crest in some forms
barred flight feathers/tail

Where: Forests, wooded farmland and edges
Food: Birds, squirrels, reptiles and small mammals
Flight / behaviour: Soars over forest; hunts from high perches

Quick ID: Very variable - shape, barring and habitat are safer clues than colour alone.

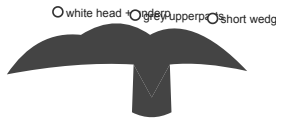
White-bellied Sea Eagle

Sea eagle

Icthyophaga leucogaster



Tisha Mukherjee • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



white head + underparts
grey upperparts
short wedge-like tail

Where: Coasts, estuaries, large rivers and reservoirs
Food: Fish, waterbirds, reptiles and carrion
Flight / behaviour: Large, broad-winged soaring over water

Quick ID: Huge coastal eagle with striking white underparts.

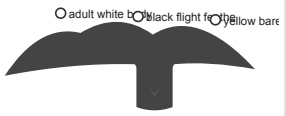
Egyptian Vulture

Vulture

Neophron percnopterus



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adult white body
black flight feathers
yellow bare face

Where: Open country, cliffs, dumps and around settlements
Food: Carrion, scraps, eggs and small animal matter
Flight / behaviour: Soars on relatively narrow wings for a vulture

Quick ID: Small pale vulture; black-and-white wings and yellow face.

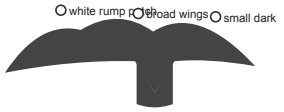
White-rumped Vulture

Vulture

Gyps bengalensis



Davidvraju • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



white rump patch
broad wings
small dark head/neck

Where: Open country, villages, wooded areas near carrion sources
Food: Carrion
Flight / behaviour: Broad-winged thermal soaring in groups

Quick ID: In flight, look for the contrasting white rump and very broad wings.

Species guide 17-18

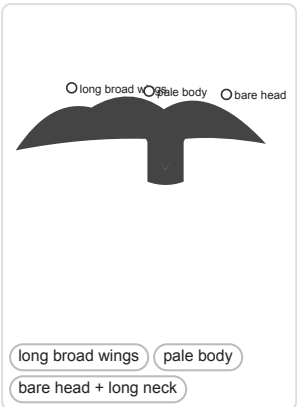
Indian Vulture

Vulture

Gyps indicus



Yann (talk) • CC BY-SA 4.0 • Wikimedia Commons



long broad wings | pale body | bare head + long neck

Where: Cliffs, open country and dry landscapes
Food: Carrion
Flight / behaviour: Large soaring vulture using thermals

Quick ID: Large Gyps vulture; long wings and pale body, often near cliffs.

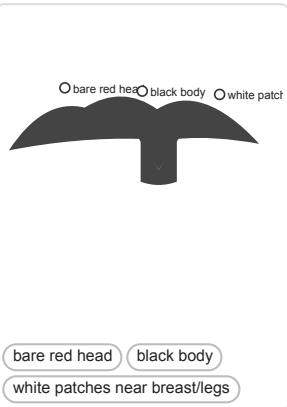
Red-headed Vulture

Vulture

Sarcogyps calvus



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bare red head | black body | white patches near breast/legs

Where: Open woodland, plains and dry country
Food: Carrion
Flight / behaviour: Broad-winged soaring, often solitary or in pairs

Quick ID: A dark vulture with a striking bare red head.

Field notes and responsible watching

How to record a difficult raptor

Write down: wing shape, tail shape, head projection, underwing pattern, wingbeat style, soaring posture, habitat, perch type, and what it was doing. A quick sketch can be more useful than trying to remember colors later.

Do not disturb

Do not approach nests, flush perched birds for a photograph, play calls repeatedly, or crowd a feeding vulture. Observe from a respectful distance.

Age and sex matter

Juveniles may look very different from adults. Shikra eye color and underpart pattern change with age/sex; eagles often have multiple plumages.

Habitat helps

City airspace favors kites and Peregrines; wooded gardens can hold Shikra; open fields suit kestrels and harriers; wetlands may attract marsh harriers and fish-eagles; cliffs and open hills can hold larger eagles.

Sources & photo notes

- Species identification notes are summarized from standard field characters used by eBird/Merlin and BirdLife resources. Shikra taxonomy follows current eBird usage: *Tachyspiza badia*.
- Real photographs in this HTML are loaded live from Wikimedia Commons search results. Each image shows the returned creator/licence metadata when available. Because Commons search is dynamic, verify any unusual image before relying on it.
- For a difficult bird, record it conservatively as “raptor sp.” and compare several field marks rather than relying on one feature.

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